

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: OA

COMPANY: Google

ROLE: SWE Intern

STORY:

Candidate passed all test cases for one problem but only partial cases for the second due to time constraints. They provided extensive comments on optimization strategies for the unfinished solution. Despite technical confidence, the candidate received a rejection email shortly after and was ghosted by the recruiter upon requesting feedback.

ROOT_CAUSE:

Inability to complete all test cases within the allotted time for the second coding problem

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

Algorithms, Data Structures, Code Optimization, Time Management

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Passed 100% of test cases for the first problem.
- Partial completion of the second problem.
- Recruiter non-responsiveness post-rejection.

COUNTERFACTUAL:

Completing all test cases for the second problem within the time limit.

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: HR

COMPANY: Amazon

ROLE: Senior SWE

STORY:

A senior developer passed the OA with 100% test cases. A recruiter requested follow-up information regarding experience, architecture contributions, and compensation expectations. After the candidate responded, the company ceased communication . The job portal later updated to "No longer under consideration" without a formal rejection or feedback.

ROOT_CAUSE:

Administrative rejection or internal withdrawal following a review of experience and compensation details .

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

System Architecture, Professional Communication, Behavioral Assessment

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Perfect score on technical OA.
- Completed extensive behavioral "Work Styles" questionnaire
- Portal status changed to "No longer under consideration" after submission of CTC/experience details.

COUNTERFACTUAL:

Unknown; likely internal business constraints or experience-to-compensation mismatch

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: OA

COMPANY: Oracle

ROLE: Data Engineer

STORY:

A candidate with 5+ years of experience solved all OA problems, passing 100% of visible sample test cases . One week later, they received a rejection. The recruiter stated the candidate "didn't pass the online test," implying failure on hidden test cases or performance/runtime issues not flagged during the live session

ROOT_CAUSE:

Failure to satisfy hidden test cases or performance constraints not visible during the assessment

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

Data Engineering, Competitive Programming, Code Efficiency **SIGNALS_OBSERVED:**

- 100% pass rate on visible sample test cases.
- Official rejection citing OA failure despite visible success.
- Candidate acknowledged being "rusty" with LeetCode-style testing.

COUNTERFACTUAL:

Optimizing code to handle edge cases and runtime efficiency for hidden validation sets.

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: OA

COMPANY: Amazon

ROLE: SWE

STORY:

Candidate passed all technical tests with near-optimal solutions and felt aligned with behavioral principles . They received a rejection email 6 hours after completion (sent at 8 AM). The candidate suspects the rapid turnaround indicates an automated rejection, possibly due to a 5-day delay in taking the OA or failing the behavioral screen.

ROOT_CAUSE:

Automated rejection triggered by behavioral assessment metrics or headcount saturation during the 5-day delay .

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

Algorithmic Problem Solving, Behavioral Alignment (Leadership Principles)

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Full technical test case completion.
- High-speed rejection (6 hours post-submission).
- Delay of 5 days before starting the OA.

COUNTERFACTUAL:

Attempting the assessment immediately upon receipt to mitigate headcount risk

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: OA

COMPANY: Meta

ROLE: SWE (Product Track)

STORY:

Candidate cleared all 4 levels of the E4 OA with 100% test cases and felt the behavioral assessment aligned with company culture . Previously, they had cleared the technical screen for the Infrastructure track but requested a transfer to the Product track. They were rejected following the Product track OA despite the successful technical results

ROOT_CAUSE:

Internal friction or different evaluation bars associated with switching from Infrastructure to Product track.

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

Algorithmic Proficiency, Behavioral Alignment

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Passed all technical OA levels.
- Success in a previous track's technical screen.
- Rejection occurred specifically after the track change.

COUNTERFACTUAL:

Remaining in the original Infrastructure track for the final loop.

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: OA

COMPANY: Google

ROLE: SWE

STORY:

A US citizen with 2 internships and a standard resume template achieved 100% scores on 10 out of 12 OAs received, including Google's. Despite perfect technical scores, the candidate faced consistent rejections before reaching the interview stage.

ROOT_CAUSE:

High applicant volume or resume filtering criteria that prioritize factors beyond OA performance .

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

LeetCode, Resume Formatting

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Consistent 100% OA pass rate across multiple firms.
- Strong pedigree (US Citizen, 2 internships, 4 projects).
- Failure to convert perfect OA scores into interview invitations.

COUNTERFACTUAL:

Unknown; potentially seeking referrals to bypass initial resume filters.

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: Tech

COMPANY: Unknown

ROLE: Backend Developer

STORY:

Candidate passed the first round but struggled in the 90-minute second round. They could provide the intuition for a circular "House Robber" problem but could not code the solution. They successfully thought through a graph DFS problem but misaligned with the interviewer on a Low-Level Design (LLD) for a parking lot .

ROOT_CAUSE:

Inability to implement code for a dynamic programming problem and failure to align on system design requirements.

SKILLS_INVOLVED

Dynamic Programming, Graph Theory (DFS), LLD

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Theoretical knowledge present (intuition) but implementation failed.
- Misunderstanding of interviewer's specific requirements for LLD.
- Interview extended beyond the scheduled hour.

COUNTERFACTUAL:

Practicing implementation of previously studied dynamic programming patterns.

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: Tech

COMPANY: Unknown

ROLE: Frontend Developer

STORY:

During a C++ interview, the candidate was asked to flatten and reverse a nested array. Confusion arose when the candidate asked about the input format; the interviewer suggested "JSON-like," which the candidate found unhelpful. Post-interview, the candidate realized the input was likely a string and felt more concrete clarification would have secured a pass .

ROOT_CAUSE:

Miscommunication regarding data input formats and lack of preparedness for string-based array parsing .

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

C++, Data Manipulation, Technical Communication

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Candidate requested clarification on technical constraints.
- Interviewer provided abstract rather than concrete technical details
- Blocked by input handling rather than core logic.

COUNTERFACTUAL:

Studying common ways non-standard data structures are represented as strings in C++ interviews.

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: Tech

COMPANY: Unknown

ROLE: Frontend Developer

STORY:

Candidate knew the logic for an "Easy" coding question and had solved harder problems in Python . However, the interview required Java, and the candidate blanked on basic syntax. They attributed this "freeze" to an over-reliance on AI coding assistants (Copilot) in their daily work.

ROOT_CAUSE:

Syntactic dependency on AI tools and lack of "vanilla" coding fluency in Java .

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

Java, Problem Solving, Language Fluency

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Discrepancy between logical understanding and implementation ability
- Candidate refused to "cheat" or use external aids during the block.
- Explicit self-identification of "Copilot" dependency

COUNTERFACTUAL:

Practicing coding in the target language without AI assistance to build muscle memory

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: HR

COMPANY: Unknown

ROLE: SDE

STORY:

After clearing technical rounds and a take-home assignment with positive feedback, the candidate was rejected after the HR round . The HR representative claimed the candidate was "too relaxed," interpreting this as a poor fit for a startup culture. The candidate noted they had worked their entire career in startups

ROOT_CAUSE:

Subjective behavioral evaluation where "confidence" was misconstrued as a lack of "startup intensity" .

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

Cultural Fit, Behavioral Communication

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Consistently positive technical feedback.
- Recruiter and HR had conflicting views on the candidate's performance.
- Rejection based solely on demeanor during the HR conversation

COUNTERFACTUAL:

Performing a more high-energy or "intense" persona to match the HR's specific cultural expectations.

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: Tech

COMPANY: Microsoft

ROLE: SWE

STORY:

In Round 1 (DSA), the candidate missed "visited tracking" in a recursion problem but solved a greedy stock problem. In Round 2 (System Design), they were asked to design an LFU cache with $O(1)$ operations. The candidate confused LFU with LRU and proposed an $O(n)$ solution, failing to derive the optimal two-linked-list approach within the time limit

ROOT_CAUSE:

Failure to derive the optimal $O(1)$ data structure for LFU cache and time lost due to internet issues

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

LLD, Cache Design (LRU/LFU), Recursion, Greedy Algorithms

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Correct intuition for greedy problems.
- Logical gap in advanced data structure design (LFU).
- Technical environmental factors (internet fluctuations) hampered implementation
- **COUNTERFACTUAL:**

Studying the specific implementation of LFU caches using frequency-based doubly linked lists.

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: System Design

COMPANY: Unknown

ROLE: SWE

STORY:

A candidate with 1.25 YOE struggled in the second half of a technical interview. They could not provide a standard hashing/base conversion approach for a URL shortener and failed to explain concurrency control (optimistic/pessimistic locking) for a seat booking system. The interviewer noted the candidate "should have known" these concepts

ROOT_CAUSE:

Lack of fundamental knowledge in HLD/LLD patterns and database concurrency

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

High-Level Design (HLD), Concurrency (Locking), URL Shortening Logic

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Initial technical questions (Java/Spring) went well.
- Complete knowledge gap on standard "BookMyShow" or "TinyURL" design problems

COUNTERFACTUAL:

Reviewing standard System Design interview patterns and database locking mechanisms

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: HR

COMPANY: Flipkart

ROLE: SWE

STORY:

Off-campus candidate solved all OA questions and fully optimized code in two technical rounds
They were rejected in the Hiring Manager (HM) round
The candidate described the interviewer as "rude" and stated the manager criticized them throughout the session

ROOT_CAUSE:

Unsuccessful cultural/managerial fit interview marked by a hostile interviewing environment

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

Technical Optimization, Stress Management, Behavioral Communication

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Excellent technical performance in early stages.
- Negative interpersonal dynamic with the hiring manager
- **COUNTERFACTUAL:**
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Unknown; outcome likely dependent on specific interviewer temperament

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: Offer

COMPANY: HCL

ROLE: SWE

STORY:

Candidate cleared 5 rounds and negotiated a salary. Both parties agreed to "meet halfway" on the number. Following this agreement, the company stopped responding to follow-up emails for three days.

ROOT_CAUSE:

Post-negotiation ghosting or internal delay in the offer approval process **SKILLS_INVOLVED:**

Negotiation, Persistence, Professional Communication **SIGNALS_OBSERVED:**

- 5 rounds cleared successfully
- Stalemate/delay occurred precisely at the final offer rollout stage **COUNTERFACTUAL:**

Unknown; likely requires further follow-up or a competing offer to force a decision

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: HR

COMPANY: Verizon

ROLE: SWE

STORY:

In an on-campus drive, 20 students reached the HR round; only 14 were selected. The candidate felt their technical round was excellent, but their HR round had "hiccups" due to network issues. They were subsequently rejected at the final stage.

ROOT_CAUSE:

Poor communication signals during HR round exacerbated by technical/network connectivity issues

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

Professionalism, Situational Communication, Resilience

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- High technical successFinal-stage rejection among a large cohortNetwork instability during the final behavioral evaluation

COUNTERFACTUAL:

Ensuring a stable internet connection or proactively rescheduling to maintain behavioral signal quality

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: Offer

COMPANY: HCLTech

ROLE: SWE

STORY:

A fresher cleared the online test, first HR round, and technical round on campus. They proceeded to the final HR video conference, which they felt went well Despite most of their panel moving forward, the candidate was not called for the final "document submission" step

ROOT_CAUSE:

Final-stage filtering during document submission or behavioral mismatch in the last round.

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

Behavioral Communication, Documentation/Compliance

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Successfully cleared 3 distinct stages.
- Exclusion from the final administrative step (document submission).

COUNTERFACTUAL:

Unknown; likely dependent on internal panel ranking .

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: Tech

COMPANY: Amazon

ROLE: Intern

STORY:

Candidate cleared two OAs and the first interview round. A second-round invite coincided with college exams. The candidate requested a delay of a few days; the company acknowledged the request but sent a rejection email 3 days later.

ROOT_CAUSE:

Inflexibility in the hiring timeline or rapid headcount filling during the requested delay .

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

Time Management, Scheduling Communication

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Multi-round technical success.
- Rejection triggered immediately following a scheduling conflict.

COUNTERFACTUAL:

Prioritizing the interview over the exam or attempting to find a same-day alternative time .

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: Tech

COMPANY: Unknown (Remote)

ROLE: Backend Intern

STORY:

Candidate cleared Round 1 (projects, fundamentals, LLD, and monotonic stack) . In Round 2, they were rejected because they had not "mastered" the specific framework used by the startup, despite having a basic project in it and showing good general understanding .

ROOT_CAUSE:

Lack of deep, specialized expertise in the specific tech stack required by the startup.

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

Framework Proficiency (Specific), HLD, ACID properties **SIGNALS_OBSERVED:**

- Strong generalist signals (solved LC medium, understood HLD).
- Rejection cited specifically as a "lack of mastery" in a single framework.

COUNTERFACTUAL:

Focusing on deep-dive expertise in a single stack rather than broad technology exposure

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: OA

COMPANY: Unknown (Campus)

ROLE: SWE

STORY:

The candidate finished an MCQ aptitude/programming exam early (15 minutes) because they felt confident in the topics. They were excluded from the results. The Placement Officer later revealed they failed because they did not write the "question paper number" on the OMR sheet, an instruction only given 20 minutes into the exam—after the candidate had already left

ROOT_CAUSE:

Procedural error caused by leaving the examination hall before all instructions were finalized

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

Attention to Detail, Patience, MCQ Proficiency

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- High technical confidence (finished in 1/4 of the time).
- Rejection for administrative non-compliance rather than technical failure

COUNTERFACTUAL:

Remaining in the exam hall for the full duration to receive all administrative updates

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: FAILURE

STAGE: Tech

COMPANY: United Airlines

ROLE: Data Science

STORY:

An HR representative noted a budget limit (17 LPA) but encouraged the candidate to proceed, promising later negotiation. The candidate passed Round 1 (45 mins) and Round 2 (1.5 hours), answering 90% of questions and case studies. Following the interviews, the candidate was ghosted with no feedback.

ROOT_CAUSE:

Likely budget misalignment that was not resolved despite the recruiter's initial assurance

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

Data Science Case Studies, Negotiation, Persistence **SIGNALS_OBSERVED:**

- Satisfactory performance in technical and case-study rounds
- Pre-existing salary tension noted before the first interview
- Total lack of post-interview communication

COUNTERFACTUAL:

Confirming budget flexibility in writing before committing to a multi-hour interview loop

===== CASE END =====

===== CASE START =====

OUTCOME: SUCCESS

STAGE: Offer

COMPANY: Remote US-based Startup

ROLE: Intern

STORY:

A student from a Tier-3 college faced over 800 rejections during their search . Despite the high failure rate and background, they eventually secured a remote internship at a US-based company with a stipend reportedly higher than typical MAANG roles.

ROOT_CAUSE:

Persistence and high-volume application strategy leading to eventual market match.

SKILLS_INVOLVED:

Persistence, Application Volume, Remote Work Readiness

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Extremely high rejection-to-success ratio (800:1)
- Successful placement from a non-target school

ASE START ===== OUTCOME: SUCCESS STAGE: Offer COMPANY: International Investment Bank ROLE: Unknown

STORY: A Tier-2 EEE student secured an offer from an international investment bank with a base salary of 12.25 LPA. Despite grinding DSA for four months leading up to the placement drive, the candidate found that the entire interview focused on their projects. The session was described as a collaborative discussion rather than a high-pressure technical "grilling" session.

ROOT_CAUSE: Strong project portfolio and ability to engage in collaborative technical discussions.

SKILLS_INVOLVED: DSA (prepared), Project Demonstration, Communication, Collaboration

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Heavy focus on project discussion over traditional DSA testing.
- Collaborative interview atmosphere.
- Rapid success in the second week of campus placements.

===== CASE START ===== OUTCOME: SUCCESS STAGE: Offer COMPANY: US BASED STARTUP

ROLE: Software Developer

STORY: A CSE student from a top state college overcame initial failures, including a rejection where an interviewer criticized their basic OS knowledge. After failing three interviews, they secured a role paying ~18 LPA focused on Cloud and GenAI. The successful interview focused on DSA, DBMS, OS, CN, and specifically how their projects solved real-world problems, which the interviewers valued over prior internship experience.

ROOT_CAUSE: Demonstrating real-world problem-solving through personal projects.

SKILLS_INVOLVED: DSA, DBMS, OS, Computer Networks, Cloud Computing, Generative AI

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Progressive improvement across four interview attempts .
- Positive response to projects solving "real problems".
- No prior internship experience was required for a high-CTC role.

===== CASE START ===== OUTCOME: SUCCESS STAGE: Offer COMPANY: Amazon ROLE: Applied Scientist L4

STORY: A Tier-1 college graduate who disliked Competitive Programming and completed fewer than 50 LeetCode problems secured an L4 Applied Scientist role at Amazon . The candidate focused early on Deep Learning and research, co-authoring two A* conference papers in NLP and Reinforcement Learning. After skipping placements to join startups and becoming a founding engineer, they were headhunted by Amazon .

ROOT_CAUSE: Specialized research expertise and publication record in high-impact AI domains.

SKILLS_INVOLVED: Deep Learning, NLP, Reinforcement Learning, Research, DSA Revision

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Direct interview call from Amazon based on profile.
- Emphasis on research (A* conferences) over standard LeetCode/CP paths.
- Career progression from startup founding engineer to Big Tech.
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===== CASE START ===== OUTCOME:

SUCCESS STAGE: Offer COMPANY: (US-based)

STORY: A student with 11 backlogs and a Tier-3 college background utilized a high-volume project strategy, hosting over 30 projects on GitHub and LinkedIn. A friend tagged them in a Facebook post where a CEO was recruiting. During the remote introduction, the CTO reviewed their project profile for 20 minutes and asked three technical questions before offering a remote role at 11 LPA .

ROOT_CAUSE: Visibility of a massive project portfolio that outweighed poor academic records.

SKILLS_INVOLVED: Project Development, Networking, Remote Communication

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- CTO hired based on project volume and technical discussion.
- Offer made immediately following the technical chat.
- Successful transition from high backlogs to high-paying remote work.
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===== CASE START ===== OUTCOME: SUCCESS STAGE: Offer COMPANY: Healthcare Startup ROLE: Unknown

STORY: After failing all on-campus interviews with an average CGPA of 7, the candidate secured an off-campus internship at IIT Bombay. They leveraged the prestige and technical work of that internship to secure an 8 LPA offer at a healthcare startup. Within one year, they

received an increment to 20 LPA, significantly outperforming peers who joined service-based firms via campus.

ROOT_CAUSE: Leveraging high-prestige internship experience to pivot to a product-based firm.

SKILLS_INVOLVED: Technical Bragging/Communication, Experience Leveraging

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- 150% salary growth within one year.
- Transition from on-campus failure to off-campus success.

===== CASE START ===== OUTCOME: SUCCESS STAGE: Offer COMPANY: Verizon ROLE:

STORY: A Tier-3 student faced a campus environment dominated by mass recruiters like Cognizant and Capgemini. By pursuing a niche path involving certifications, specialized trainings, and targeted projects, they secured a role at Verizon with a CTC of 9.5 LPA. This CTC was more than double the college median of 4 LPA.

ROOT_CAUSE: Niche specialization and certification to stand out in a mass-recruitment environment.

SKILLS_INVOLVED: Niche Certifications, Training, Project Building

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Successfully bypassed low-paying mass recruiter roles.
- Significant deviation from college median CTC.

===== CASE START ===== OUTCOME: SUCCESS STAGE: Offer COMPANY:
Well-established Startup ROLE: Frontend Developer

STORY: The candidate started as an intern at a small startup for 7k/month in 2022. By taking full ownership of the frontend web app and working directly with founders, they learned rapidly. Over two years, they switched roles twice—moving to a remote offer (10 LPA), then a PBC via referral (16 LPA), and finally a startup at 26 LPA base . They emphasize that "ownership spoke louder than fancy side projects".

ROOT_CAUSE: Aggressive ownership of product features and a track record of rapid career jumps.

SKILLS_INVOLVED: JavaScript, React, TypeScript, Product Ownership, Technical Branding

SIGNALS_OBSERVED:

- Salary growth from 6 LPA to 26 LPA base in two years.
- Final offers received via HR outreach rather than active applications.
- Use of LinkedIn for personal branding.